



The Two Names I Answer To

Teacher copy (everything in the student copy, plus answers and teaching notes)

The article, marked for rhetorical devices (one color throughout):

1 At 7:40 in the morning I am Daniela, and by 9:00 I am Dani. The change happens somewhere on the F train, between my mother's kitchen and the elevator on the eleventh floor. My mother fed me eggs and a story about my aunt's knee, all of it in Spanish, the warm kind that slides one word into the next. Then I walked into a glass lobby and flattened my vowels so a man named Greg would not have to lean in to hear me. I have done this for sixteen years. I never decided to.

2 You might expect me, here, to tell you this is a tragedy. The story has a familiar shape: the daughter loses the mother tongue, the office eats the home, something pure gets sanded down for a paycheck. I am supposed to mourn. But I will not hand you that story, because it is not the one I lived, and the tidy version would be a lie I told to sound wise.

3 Here is what is actually true. About 43 percent of the people on this planet speak more than one language every day, roughly 1.5 billion of us, and we do not walk around grieving. [Anecdotal vs statistical evidence] We switch. Linguists have a flat, unromantic word for it, code-switching, and they have shown it is not sloppiness or loss but a thing speakers do on purpose, to fit the room, to claim a person, to mean exactly what they mean. I switch to Spanish when my mother is tired. I switch to English when Greg needs a number by noon. I switch to something in between with my cousin, who does both at once. [Anaphora] The brain runs both systems side by side; it is not choosing one and killing the other.

4 What the word 'code-switching' got wrong, for me, was the word 'code.' A code is a thing you crack, a secret with a single hidden answer underneath. But the Spanish I speak at the table and the English I speak at the desk are not two disguises over one real face. They are two faces, and both of them are mine. [Metaphor] There is a phrase researchers use now, translanguaging, the idea that a bilingual person is not running two separate machines but one wide one. I read that and felt seen, which is an embarrassing thing to admit about a journal article.

5 I will not pretend the switch is free. There is a cost the textbooks name and I can feel: the small tax of deciding, every hour, who gets which version of me. [Concession] On the worst days I have stood in that glass lobby and felt the old thing the linguists call linguistic insecurity, the suspicion that the Spanish makes me less, that Greg's English is the real currency and mine is the soft money. My father, who only speaks English, used to call the firm 'the big leagues.' He meant it kindly.

6 So I am not going to tell you to pick a language and be whole. I wish you two kitchens. I wish you the eggs and the spreadsheet, the vowels you flatten and the ones you let spread out warm. [Anaphora] I wish you a self too big for one room. The research says people who lose one language to keep the other tend to belong less, in both places, not more. I believe that, though I mostly believe my mother, who has never read a study and switched to English on the phone today, for me, badly, and on purpose.

Devices, and why they are here:

Anecdotal vs statistical evidence (paragraph 3): “Here is what is actually true. About 43 percent of the people on this planet speak more than one language every day, roughly 1.5 billion of us, and we do not walk around grieving.”

The writer deliberately reaches for the hard 43 percent and 1.5 billion figures (from the fact spine) in a register that otherwise runs on personal scene, using the unromantic statistic to puncture the expected tragedy and prove she is one of a vast normal majority, not a casualty.

Anaphora (paragraph 3): “I switch to Spanish when my mother is tired. I switch to English when Greg needs a number by noon. I switch to something in between with my cousin, who does both at once.”

The repeated frame 'I switch to...' at the start of successive sentences confides rather than hammers, accumulating warmth and showing code-switching as ordinary, chosen, and relational instead of a loss.

Metaphor (paragraph 4): “But the Spanish I speak at the table and the English I speak at the desk are not two disguises over one real face. They are two faces, and both of them are mine.”

Recasting the languages as two faces that are both hers (against the idea of disguises over one real face) carries the piece's central claim about identity in a single concrete image rather than asserting it.

Concession (paragraph 5): “I will not pretend the switch is free. There is a cost the textbooks name and I can feel: the small tax of deciding, every hour, who gets which version of me.”

The writer grants the real cost of switching, the hourly tax and the linguistic insecurity, before refusing the tragedy frame, so the refusal lands as honest rather than as denial; the concession costs her something and earns the close.

Anaphora (paragraph 6): “I wish you two kitchens. I wish you the eggs and the spreadsheet, the vowels you flatten and the ones you let spread out warm.”

The 'I wish you...' refrain enacts the Withheld-Turn close, substituting a blessing for the expected directive and handing the redefined idea of code-switching to the reader as a gift instead of a warning.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. In the second paragraph, the writer names the 'familiar shape' of the story (the daughter losing the mother tongue, the office eating the home) primarily in order to

- A) concede that her own experience matches the conventional account of cultural loss
- B) set up an expected interpretation she will then refuse, so her actual claim arrives as a correction of it
- C) establish her credibility by showing she has read the scholarship on language shift
- D) appeal to readers' emotions by dwelling on the sadness of a lost heritage language

2. In the fourth paragraph, the shift from 'A code is a thing you crack' to 'They are two faces, and both of them are mine' best supports which claim about the writer's tone toward her two languages?

- A) She remains anxious that one language will always undermine the other
- B) She moves from treating them as a problem to be solved toward an unforced acceptance of holding both
- C) She becomes coolly analytic, treating her identity as a linguistics case study
- D) She grows defiant, insisting her Spanish is superior to the English her workplace rewards

Multiple choice answer key:

1. Answer B. The paragraph builds the conventional tragedy ('I am supposed to mourn') only to reject it ('But I will not hand you that story'), so the familiar shape exists to be declined. The option saying her experience matches the conventional account inverts the relationship, since she explicitly says it is not the story she lived. The option about credibility through scholarship imports a purpose tied to a different span, the statistics and named research in later paragraphs, not this one. The option about dwelling on sadness mistakes a setup she dismantles for an emotional appeal she is actually refusing to make.

2. Answer B. The turn rejects the 'crack a code' framing (one hidden answer) for owning both faces as hers, an acceptance, not a solution imposed from outside. The anxious-undermining option names a real feeling but locates it wrongly: the insecurity belongs to the fifth paragraph, not this turn. The defiant-superiority option overstates into a ranking the text never makes; she calls both faces hers, not one better. The coolly-analytic option is contradicted by her admission that the journal article made her feel 'seen,' an emotional response, not detached analysis.

Discussion questions:

1. The writer sets up the 'tragedy' version of her story and then refuses it. What does she offer the reader instead, and why might she consider the refused version 'a lie I told to sound wise'?
2. Trace how the writer redefines the word 'code.' How does shifting from 'a thing you crack' to 'two faces' change what code-switching means in the piece, and does the personal evidence earn that redefinition?

Sample strong discussion responses:

1. The expected story is one of loss: the daughter's Spanish fades, work crowds out home, and she is meant to mourn. The writer refuses it because it did not happen to her; she presents code-switching as a normal, chosen act shared by 43 percent of the world rather than a wound. Calling the tragic version 'a lie I told to sound wise' admits that mourning would have been the easy, flattering pose. The honest account is messier, since she concedes a real cost (the hourly tax, the linguistic insecurity in the lobby) yet still declines to call her two-language life a defeat.
2. The writer first treats 'code' as something with a single hidden answer underneath, implying one of her selves must be the real one and the other a disguise. She then rejects that with the metaphor of two faces, 'both of them are mine,' so neither language masks a truer self. The personal evidence earns the turn: the eggs-and-story breakfast in Spanish and the flattened vowels for Greg are both shown as genuine, and the translanguaging idea (one wide system, not two machines) gives the redefinition a research anchor without letting the study do the emotional work the scenes already did.

Writing prompt (Homework or extended in-class, Q2 rhetorical analysis):

The following passage is a first-person reflection by a bilingual professional on switching between Spanish at home and English at work. Read the passage carefully. Then, in a well-developed essay, analyze the rhetorical choices the writer makes to convey her changing understanding of what it means to move between her two languages. In your response you should do the following: respond to the prompt with a defensible thesis that analyzes the writer's rhetorical choices; select and use evidence to support your line of reasoning; explain how the evidence supports your line of reasoning; and demonstrate an understanding of the rhetorical situation.

Common misconceptions to watch for:

- Students may read the opening statistics (43 percent, 1.5 billion) as the writer's main point or as a bid to sound authoritative, when she uses statistical evidence in tension with her personal anecdotes precisely to deny the expected tragedy; the marked 'anecdotal vs statistical evidence' span is a deliberate clash, not a data dump.
- Students often misread the two 'I switch to...' runs and the 'I wish you...' run as the same device or as mere repetition; both are anaphora (repetition at the START of successive clauses), and they should distinguish anaphora from plain repetition and from parallelism that recurs mid-clause.
- Students may take the 'two faces' line literally as a claim about physical appearance or deception, missing that it is a metaphor for two genuine selves; reading the figurative phrase at face value loses the writer's actual point about identity.
- Students may treat the admission of cost (the hourly tax, linguistic insecurity) as proof the writer agrees code-switching is harmful, missing that this is a concession she grants before turning away from the tragedy frame, not her conclusion.

AP exam alignment:

This opener teaches students to recognize the Withheld-Turn structure, where a writer names the interpretation the reader expects and then declines it, and to see how first-person anecdote can be braided with statistical evidence to advance a claim rather than merely decorate it. It targets AP reading skills in Reasoning and Organization (how the refused 'tragedy' frame organizes the argument) and Style (how a redefinition and a controlling metaphor convey tone), and it gives students a rhetorical-analysis prompt grounded in clear, markable choices.